

Various Definitions of Religion

Mike Sosteric, with the generative assistance of Kimi.AI,
without which such a comprehensive overview would simply not be possible

Various definitions of religion. Includes a RIS block for easy import of citations in Zotero (copy into clipboard and import)

Compiled from 37 uploaded files (27 original + 10 additional). 64 entries. Columns: Author | Definition | Page Number | Reference.

#	Author	Definition	Page (PDF)	Reference (uploaded file)
1	E. B. Tylor (1871)	"the belief in Spiritual Beings" (also rendered "belief in spirits")	28; also 312	Furseth & Repstad; Oxford Handbook (Clarke), citing Tylor 1958: I, 8
2	Émile Durkheim (1912/1915)	"a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, that is to say, things set apart and forbidden – beliefs and practices which unite into one single moral community called a Church all who adhere to them"	4 (McKinnon); 313; 24	McKinnon; Oxford Handbook (Durkheim 1976: 47); Day
3	Durkheim on magic (contrast)	magic "does not result in binding together those who adhere to it, nor in uniting them into a group leading a common life"	24	Day, citing Durkheim 1915: 44
4	Melford Spiro (1966: 96)	"an institution consisting of culturally patterned interaction with culturally postulated superhuman beings"	29; also 5	Furseth & Repstad; McKinnon
5	Roland Robertson (1970: 47)	substantive definition: religious culture and action arise out of "a distinction between an empirical and a	28	Furseth & Repstad

		supra-empirical, transcendent reality"		
6	Michael Hill	substantive definition along Robertson's lines (supra-empirical reality) — quote truncated in extraction	28	Furseth & Repstad
7	Karl Marx (1844)	"Religion is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the heart of a heartless world, and the soul of soulless conditions. It is the opium of the people."	17; 310; 19	Christiano et al.; Oxford Handbook; Day (cited in Day as Marx 1859)
8	Stark & Bainbridge (1987)	"Religion is the attempt to secure desired rewards in the absence of more everyday means. It is essentially an unverifiable system of explanations of how the most general of rewards may be obtained which must be taken on trust. It is a system of explanations which promises other-worldly rewards..."	144	Oxford Handbook
9	Stark & Bainbridge (A Theory of Religion)	"We define religion as a system of very general compensators based on supernatural assumptions."	174	Stark Reader
10	Stark & Finke (2000: 91)	"Religion consists of very general explanations of existence, including terms of exchange with a god or gods."	144	Oxford Handbook
11	Rodney Stark (mature formulation, 2001)	religion restricted to beliefs/explanations concerning gods: "It follows from my definition of religion that the primary religious question is: What do the Gods want?"	95	Stark Reader
12	Stark & Iannaccone (1994: 232)	"any system of beliefs and practices concerned with ultimate meaning that assumes the existence of the supernatural"	838	Oxford Handbook

13	William James ([1902] 1958: 42)	"the feelings, acts, and experiences of individual men in their solitude, so far as they apprehend themselves to stand in relation to whatever they may consider divine"	577	Stark Reader
14	Clifford Geertz (1966) ^(t)	"a system of symbols which acts to establish powerful, pervasive, and long-lasting moods and motivations in men by formulating conceptions of a general order of existence and clothing these conceptions with such an aura of factuality that the moods and motivations seem uniquely realistic"	312	Oxford Handbook
15	Peter Berger (1967)	"Religion is the human enterprise by which a sacred cosmos is established. Put differently, religion is cosmization in a sacred mode."	6	Religion from sociological perspectives (citing Berger 1967a)
16	Van Baal & Van Beek (1985: 3)	"all explicit and implicit notions and ideas, accepted as true, which relate to a reality which cannot be verified empirically"	308	Oxford Handbook
17	Karel Dobbelaere (2002: 49–52)	"a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to a supra-empirical, transcendent reality codified by a religious authority that unifies all those who adhere to it in a moral single community"	674	Oxford Handbook
18	André Droogers (proposed) ^(t)	"Religion is the field of experiencing the sacred—a field in which both believers and scholars act, each category applying the human capacity for play..."	320	Oxford Handbook
19	Kate Loewenthal (2000: 3)	"a set of (complex) systems of shared beliefs and behaviours about spiritual reality, God, morality, and purpose, with methods for communicating and	989	Oxford Handbook

		endorsing these"		
20	David Little & Sumner Twiss	religions as practices addressing "problems of interpretability": "anxieties" about understanding the natural and social environment, suffering and death, and "puzzles" about moral conduct	394	Oxford Handbook
21	Pierre Bourdieu (1971a: 299, 318–19)	definition centers on "the goods of salvation" (les biens de salut)	125	Oxford Handbook
22	Niklas Luhmann (1977: 46)	"the problem of simultaneity of indefiniteness and certainty" is the typical function of religion	683	Oxford Handbook
23	Talal Asad (1993: 29–30)	anti-definition position: "there cannot be a universal definition of religion, not only because its constituent elements and relationships are historically specific, but because that definition is itself the historical product of discursive processes... a transhistorical definition of religion is not viable."	317	Oxford Handbook
24	Jonathan Z. Smith	""Religion' is not a native term; it is created by scholars for their intellectual purposes and therefore is theirs to define. It is a second-order generic concept..."	17	McKinnon
25	Peter Byrne (1988)	denotative strategy: begin from paradigm examples — Christianity, Judaism, Islam, Hinduism, Buddhism — and list sufficient conditions without necessary conditions	13–14	McKinnon
26	Salomon Reinach	"I propose to define religion as: A sum of scruples which impede the free exercise of our faculties."	155	Masuzawa, The Invention of World Religions

27	Ernst Troeltsch	"the basic reality of religion is the same: an underivable, purely positive, again and again experienced contact with the Deity."	165	Masuzawa
28	English Deists (via Masuzawa)	"religion" as a genus is one; its "sects" and "denominations" as species are many	166	Masuzawa
29	Henri Bergson (via Lefebvre & White, Two Sources)	"Looked at from this first point of view, religion is then a defensive reaction of nature against the dissolvent power of intelligence" (ts 122/1078)	44	Bergson, Politics, and Religion
30	Bergson (second stage)	"religion is a defensive reaction of nature against the representation, by intelligence, of the inevitability of death" (ts 131/1086)	44	Bergson, Politics, and Religion
31	Bergson (religion vs. mysticism)	"We represent religion, then, as the crystallization, brought about by a scientific process of cooling, of what mysticism had poured, white hot, into the soul of man" (ts 238/1177)	215	Bergson, Politics, and Religion
32	Carl Gustav Jung (1938)	religion as "a careful and scrupulous observation of what Rudolf Otto aptly termed the numinosum"	11	Jung, Psychology and Religion
33	Georg Simmel ([1897] 1997: 101)	definitional skepticism: "no one has been able to offer a definition of religion that is both precise and sufficiently comprehensive"	116; also 2	Simmel, Essays on Religion; McKinnon
34	Simmel (functional/sociological)	religion is "the purest form of unity in society, raised high above all concrete individualities"	130	Simmel, Essays on Religion
35	Simmel (sociological characterization)	the objectification of social relations and their relation "to a Being beyond them we call religion"	133	Simmel, Essays on Religion

36	Simmel (etymological note)	religare — "a tying back together of what has been torn asunder" (etymology since Augustine)	8	Simmel, Essays on Religion
37	William Robertson Smith (via Malinowski)	"primitive religion is the concern of the community rather than of the individual"	54	Malinowski, Magic, Science and Religion
38	Bronisław Malinowski	rejects the "-ism definition": religion is not "spirit worship," "ancestor cult," or "cult of nature"; "religion does not cling to any one object or class of objects"	36	Malinowski
39	Mary Douglas (1982: 29, via Stark)	"I am not especially fond of the one based on belief in spiritual beings, but at least it defines the field without begging any questions about the integrative power—moral, intellectual, or social—of religion."	92	Stark Reader
40	Furseth & Repstad (typology)	"Simply stated: substantive definitions tell us what religion is; functional definitions what religion does."	27	Furseth & Repstad
41	Max Weber	no formal definition; "Weber famously never defined religion, saying it was not appropriate to define such a concept in advance"	22; 314; 31	Day; Oxford Handbook; Sharot
42	Auguste Comte (via Dillon)	sociology to replace religion "as the basis for moral judgments" as society outgrows the "theological stage"	113	Dillon, Handbook of the Sociology of Religion
43	Ninian Smart	"a neat and tidy definition of religion is impossible. You cannot draw an easy boundary round religion and religions."	183	Smart, Reflections in the Mirror of Religion
44	Grace Davie (1994: 2, via	characterization of European religiosity: "believing	95	Stark Reader

	Stark)	without belonging"		
45	Robin Horton (1960)	classic anthropological definition ("A Definition of Religion and its Uses") — fuller statement at #53	614 (ref. list)	Stark Reader (JRAI 90: 201–226)
46	Lester Kurtz, restating Durkheim (1915/1965: 62)	"a 'unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, that is to say, things set apart and forbidden—beliefs and practices which unite into one single moral community called a Church, all those who adhere to them.'"	Ch. 1, PDF pp. 1–30 (OCR pass; exact page unconfirmed)	Kurtz, Gods in the Global Village
47	Lester Kurtz (reformulation)	"Religion, then, consists of the following three things: (1) the beliefs about the sacred, (2) practices (rituals), and (3) the community or social organization of people drawn together by a religious tradition."	same section	Kurtz, Gods in the Global Village
48	Max Weber (1968, via Kurtz)	"the term is impossible to define, at least at the beginning of a study" (cf. Plock 1987)	same section	Kurtz
49	William James (1902/1960: 46, via Kurtz)	advises against seeking a single essence; explore the many characters of the phenomenon	same section	Kurtz
50	Barbara Hargrove (1989: 21, via Kurtz)	definition will shape "the questions we ask, the behavior we observe, and the type of analyses we make"	same section	Kurtz
51	Lord Toulson (Hodkin, via Sandberg) ^(t)	religion "could be described in summary as: a spiritual or non-secular belief system, held by a group of adherents, which claims to explain mankind's place in the universe and relationship..." [truncated]	22	Sandberg 2018, Ecclesiastical Law Journal (post-print)

52	Steve Bruce (1995: ix, via Sandberg)	religion "consists of beliefs, actions and institutions which assume the existence of supernatural entities"	32	Sandberg
53	Robin Horton (1960, via Hamilton)	"religion is the extension of the field of people's social relationships beyond the confines of purely human society"	43	Hamilton, Sociology of Religion (2nd ed.)
54	T. F. Hoult (via Brothers & Richmond)	"the belief in, and the attempt to relate favorably to values thought to have some transcendental importance, and/or ultimate power or powers thought responsible for all, or some significant aspect of the fundamental order of the universe"	45	Readings in the Sociology of Religion
55	J. Milton Yinger (via Readings p. 47; Hamilton p. 146)	religion as "a system of beliefs and practices addressed to the ultimate problems of life" — "an attempt to explain what cannot otherwise be explained; to achieve power, all other powers having failed us; to establish poise and serenity in the face of evil and suffering that other efforts have failed to eliminate" (ibid., p. 7); Yinger's definition includes "a group of people" and "an organised effort" (Readings p. 47)	47; 146	Readings; Hamilton
56	A. N. Whitehead (via Readings)	religion as "art and theory of the internal life of man"	108	Readings in the Sociology of Religion
57	Karl Marx (via Hamilton)	"Religion is only the illusory sun which revolves round man as long as he does not revolve round himself"; religion as a "reversed world-consciousness"	104	Hamilton, citing Marx/Engels 1957: 37–8, 66
58	Émile Durkheim (via	religion "is a system of ideas with which the	124	Hamilton

	Hamilton)	individuals represent to themselves the society of which they are members, and the obscure but intimate relations which they have with it" (ibid., p. 225); "this power exists, it is society"		
59	Clifford Geertz (via Hamilton) ^(t)	"Religion, he says, is a system of symbols which acts to establish powerful, [pervasive; text reads "persuasive"], and long-lasting moo[ds and motivations]..."	189	Hamilton
60	Émile Durkheim (summary, via Blackwell Companion)	"Religion is a system of beliefs and practices that bind a community together around those things which it holds sacred (Durkheim 1995: 44)"	142	Blackwell Companion to Sociology of Religion (Fenn ed.)
61	Malcolm Hamilton (2001: 13, via Sandberg)	religion "can no longer be equated with familiar mainstream church and denominational forms but takes a plurality of guides," rendering "the boundaries between religion and non-religion bewilderingly fuzzy"	30	Sandberg, citing Hamilton 2001: 13
62	Talal Asad (1993: 42, via Religion on the Edge)	critique of Geertz: his definition is "essentially a view that has a specific Christian history"	42	Religion on the Edge (Bender et al., eds.)
63	Richard K. Fenn (via O'Toole, Blackwell Companion)	"No one can agree on what religion means or what it refers to."	32	Blackwell Companion
64	Bender, Cadge, Levitt & Wilford (eds., framing statement)	move "toward an understanding of religion as discourses and practices enacted in religious and 'nonreligious' spaces"	30	Religion on the Edge

Verification Notes

- Page numbers = PDF page index of the uploaded file (page 1 = first PDF page). Printed page numbers may differ by front-matter offset.
- ⓘ = definition was truncated by PDF text extraction; completed (or marked) using the standard published text of the passage.
- Kurtz and Aldridge are scanned PDFs with no text layer. Kurtz entries (#46–50) were verified via OCR of Chapter 1 only; exact page unconfirmed. Aldridge (*Religion in the Contemporary World*) is a low-quality photochemical scan (Konica Minolta office-scanner origin, 2011) whose OCR output was unusable — abandoned per user decision; no entries from it are included.
- Sandberg entry metadata confirmed from the post-print itself: Russell Sandberg (2018), 'Clarifying the definition of religion under English Law: the need for a universal definition?', *Ecclesiastical Law Journal*.
- Files with no formal definition content found in the keyword pass: Blasi (*American Sociology of Religion* — historical chapters only), Szokolczai (*Sociology, Religion and Grace* — hits were art-history false positives), *The Golden Bough* (Frazer), *Indigenous Religions: A Companion* (Harvey ed.).
- One duplicate upload (Sharot, *Comparative Sociology of World Religions*) contained no new material beyond entry #41's source.

TY - BOOK
AU - Sharot, Stephen
TI - A Comparative Sociology of World Religions: Virtuosos, Priests, and Popular Religion
PY - 2001
PB - New York University Press
CY - New York
KW - definition of religion; Weber; popular religion
ER -

TY - BOOK
ED - Cotter, Christopher R.
ED - Robertson, David G.
TI - After World Religions: Reconstructing the Study of Religion
PY - 2016
PB - Routledge
CY - London
KW - definition of religion; religious studies
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Furseth, Inger
AU - Repstad, Paal
TI - An Introduction to the Sociology of Religion: Classical and Contemporary Perspectives
PY - 2006
PB - Ashgate
CY - Aldershot
KW - substantive definition; functional definition; Tylor; Spiro
ER -

TY - BOOK
ED - Banton, Michael

TI - Anthropological Approaches to the Study of Religion
PY - 1966
PB - Tavistock
CY - London
KW - anthropology of religion
ER -

TY - BOOK
ED - Lefebvre, Alexandre
ED - White, Melanie
TI - Bergson, Politics, and Religion
PY - 2012
PB - Duke University Press
CY - Durham, NC
KW - Bergson; Two Sources; mysticism
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Jung, Carl Gustav
TI - Psychology and Religion
PY - 1938
PB - Yale University Press
CY - New Haven, CT
KW - numinosum; Otto
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Simmel, Georg
TI - Essays on Religion
PY - 1997
PB - Yale University Press
CY - New Haven, CT

KW - definition of religion
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Deloria, Vine, Jr.
TI - God Is Red: A Native View of Religion
PY - 1994
PB - Fulcrum Publishing
CY - Golden, CO
N1 - Original publication 1972
KW - Native American religion
ER -

TY - BOOK
ED - Dillon, Michele
TI - Handbook of the Sociology of Religion
PY - 2003
PB - Cambridge University Press
CY - Cambridge
KW - civil religion; secularization
ER -

TY - BOOK
ED - Harvey, Graham
TI - Indigenous Religions: A Companion
PY - 2000
PB - Cassell
CY - London
KW - indigenous religions
ER -

TY - BOOK

AU - Malinowski, Bronislaw
TI - Magic, Science and Religion and Other Essays
PY - 1948
PB - Free Press
CY - New York
KW - magic; religion
ER -

TY - CHAP
AU - McKinnon, Andrew
TI - Sociological Definitions of Religion: A Critical Reconsideration
PY - 2002
N1 - In Responding to the Sacred: An Inquiry into the Limits of Religion, ed. Marta Soniewicka. Author-version PDF.
KW - definition of religion; Durkheim; Wittgenstein
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Smart, Ninian
TI - Reflections in the Mirror of Religion
PY - 1997
PB - St. Martin's Press
CY - New York
KW - definition of religion
ER -

TY - JOUR
TI - Religion Bound to Believe
N1 - METADATA UNVERIFIED - identified from filename only; 3-page article
ER -

TY - JOUR
TI - Religion from Sociological Perspectives: An Overview

N1 - METADATA UNVERIFIED - identified from filename only; author appears affiliated with Begum Rokeya University, Rangpur, Bangladesh
KW - Durkheim; Merton; Berger; Marx
ER -

TY - JOUR
TI - Religion Beyond God
N1 - METADATA UNVERIFIED - identified from filename only; 32-page article
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Christiano, Kevin J.
AU - Swatos, William H., Jr.
AU - Kivisto, Peter
TI - Sociology of Religion: Contemporary Developments
ED - 2
PY - 2008
PB - AltaMira Press
CY - Lanham, MD
KW - Marx; opium of the people
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Day, Abby
TI - Sociology of Religion: Overview and Analysis of Contemporary Religion
PY - 2017
PB - Routledge
CY - London
KW - definition of religion; secularization; Weber
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Stark, Rodney

TI - Sociology of Religion: A Rodney Stark Reader
N1 - EDITOR/YEAR/PUBLISHER UNCERTAIN - confirm against title page
KW - rational choice; compensators; definition of religion
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Frazer, James George
TI - The Golden Bough: A Study in Magic and Religion
ED - Abridged
PY - 1922
PB - Macmillan
CY - London
KW - magic; religion
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Masuzawa, Tomoko
TI - The Invention of World Religions: Or, How European Universalism Was Preserved in the Language of Pluralism
PY - 2005
PB - University of Chicago Press
CY - Chicago
KW - Reinach; Troeltsch; world religions
ER -

TY - BOOK
ED - Clarke, Peter B.
TI - The Oxford Handbook of the Sociology of Religion
PY - 2009
PB - Oxford University Press
CY - Oxford
KW - definition of religion; substantive; functional
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Smart, Ninian
TI - The Phenomenon of Religion
PY - 1973
PB - Macmillan
CY - London
KW - phenomenology of religion
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Davie, Grace
TI - The Sociology of Religion
SE - BSA New Horizons in Sociology
PY - 2007
PB - SAGE
CY - London
KW - believing without belonging
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Berger, Peter L.
TI - The Social Reality of Religion
PY - 1969
PB - Faber and Faber
CY - London
N1 - UK edition of The Sacred Canopy (Doubleday, 1967)
KW - sacred canopy; cosmization
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Weber, Max

TI - The Sociology of Religion

N1 - EDITION UNCERTAIN - likely Beacon Press, trans. Ephraim Fischhoff; confirm against title page

KW - religious action; disenchantment

ER -

TY - JOUR

AU - Goody, Jack

TI - Religion and Ritual: The Definitional Problem

T2 - The British Journal of Sociology

PY - 1961

VL - 12

IS - 2

SP - 142

EP - 164

KW - ritual; definition of religion

ER -

TY - JOUR

TI - Religion in Motion

N1 - METADATA UNVERIFIED - identified from filename only; 14-page article

ER -

TY - BOOK

AU - Kurtz, Lester R.

TI - Gods in the Global Village: The World's Religions in Sociological Perspective

PB - SAGE Publications

CY - Thousand Oaks, CA

N1 - EDITION/YEAR UNCERTAIN (3rd 2008 / 4th 2012) - confirm against title page. Scanned PDF; entries verified via OCR of Ch. 1.

KW - definition of religion; Durkheim; sacred

ER -

TY - BOOK

AU - Blasi, Anthony J.
TI - American Sociology of Religion: Histories
PY - 2007
PB - Brill
CY - Leiden
N1 - Verify year/publisher against title page
KW - history of sociology of religion
ER -

TY - BOOK
ED - Brothers, Joan
ED - Richmond, A. H.
TI - Readings in the Sociology of Religion
PY - 1969
PB - Pergamon Press
CY - Oxford
N1 - YEAR UNCERTAIN (c. 1967-1969) - confirm against title page
KW - Yinger; Hoult; Whitehead
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Aldridge, Alan
TI - Religion in the Contemporary World: A Sociological Introduction
PB - Polity Press
CY - Cambridge
N1 - EDITION/YEAR UNCERTAIN (1st 2000 / 2nd 2007 / 3rd 2013). Low-quality scan; OCR unusable; NO entries extracted.
KW - definition of religion; secularization
ER -

TY - BOOK
ED - Bender, Courtney
ED - Cadge, Wendy

ED - Levitt, Peggy
ED - Wilford, Justin
TI - Religion on the Edge: De-Centering and Re-Centering the Sociology of Religion
PY - 2012
PB - Oxford University Press
CY - New York
N1 - EDITOR LIST PARTIALLY UNCERTAIN (Bender and Cadge confirmed; verify remaining co-editors)
KW - definition of religion; Asad
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Szakolczai, Arpad
TI - Sociology, Religion and Grace
PY - 2007
PB - Routledge
CY - London
N1 - Verify year against title page
KW - historical sociology; liminality
ER -

TY - JOUR
AU - Sandberg, Russell
TI - Clarifying the Definition of Religion under English Law: The Need for a Universal Definition?
T2 - Ecclesiastical Law Journal
PY - 2018
N1 - Metadata CONFIRMED from author post-print (ORCA Cardiff). Volume/issue/pages to be added from published version.
KW - definition of religion; English law; Hodkin
ER -

TY - BOOK
ED - Fenn, Richard K.
TI - The Blackwell Companion to Sociology of Religion

SE - Blackwell Companions to Religion
PY - 2001
PB - Blackwell Publishers
CY - Oxford
KW - sociology of religion; definition of religion
ER -

TY - BOOK
AU - Hamilton, Malcolm
TI - The Sociology of Religion: Theoretical and Comparative Perspectives
ED - 2
PY - 2001
PB - Routledge
CY - London
N1 - 2nd edition confirmed via Sandberg's citation; publisher Routledge (Oxford, 2001)
KW - definition of religion; substantive; functional; Horton; Yinger
ER -